

Infusing New Vision, Energy and Engagement at VELS

Dr. Preethaa Ganesh, Vice-President, VELS Group of Institutions, is a young self-motivated visionary, out to change the educational landscape of India with her innovative ideas. An achiever herself, she sees great untapped potential in the youth of this country and is going all out to provide them every opportunity that would empower them as dynamic trend setters, transforming the society for better and brighter days ahead.



Dr. Preethaa Ganesh

Vice-President, VELS Group of Institutions

What set you on the path of entrepreneurship, and as you progressed to a leading position how has the experience of the journey been for you?

Born into a family of entrepreneurs, it was only a matter of time before I made the decision to join my parents, who have been successful first-generation entrepreneurs themselves. On observing the impact good education can create on an individual and the society as a whole, I wanted to join the education vertical, despite Vels' presence in multiple sectors.

I knew that I had to take the legacy forward in a family where I am the eldest among three siblings. However, the journey to where I am today was not any less easy. Along the way I realized that I had to live up to the expectations of building quality, taking the institutions to a global stage as well as bringing in new institutions into the fold of the Vels Group. With one new institution getting added to the Vels umbrella each year, my journey so far has been challenging, rewarding and full of learning.

As an edupreneur, how have you cultivated an academic temper on the VELS campus for creating a robust education ecosystem?

In the face of an increasingly volatile, uncertain, complex and ambiguous world, education can make the difference as to whether people embrace the challenges they are confronted with or whether they are defeated by them.

The education ecosystem has to prepare students empowering them for jobs that have not yet been created, for technologies that have not yet been

invented, to solve problems that have not yet been anticipated.

To ensure that the education ecosystem is robust, we need to impart the transformative competencies, the 4Cs of 21st century skills (e.g. creativity, critical thinking, communication, collaboration) need to be incorporated. These four skills are essential for modern students to succeed in university and the workplace alike.

At the VELS campus, we open up a healthy ecosystem with active collaboration among various stakeholders. We have business incubation centres in the campus to promote entrepreneurship among the students. For those with a penchant for research, we open up the doors to various major and minor funded research projects. VISTAS also provides international exposure to the students through Global Immersion Programmes and Internships. The faculty of various departments are encouraged to submit quality papers in peer reviewed journals and are encouraged with active support to attend seminars and conferences both in India and abroad.

VFund is aimed at identifying women entrepreneurs, encouraging them and empowering them. Could you share more details about the endeavour?

This initiative stemmed from the fact that women entrepreneurs in our country have been extremely talented and the likes of Kiran Mazumdar Shaw, Falguni Nayar and Vineeta Singh are a few shining examples of those who have risen from their humble beginnings.

Countless women in our country desire to become entrepreneurs but are unable to sustain because of various stereotypes in addition to the lack of financial support. Covid-19 further exacerbated the existing gender inequality. So, in 2020 I decided to float V-Fund Women on Women's Day to fund budding women entrepreneurs. The previous two editions have witnessed enormous responses. I'm happy that we have been able to give the initial thrust to many women-led businesses which run profitably today. Of course, this funding comes at no interest and that should ease their burden as they start off the blocks.

A healthy body has a healthy mind. As a passionate sports person, how are you inculcating youngsters to take to the playground and encourage those who are talented?

Be it the schools or the institutions of higher learning that we manage, we aim for the holistic development of our students and sports has almost and always taken centre stage. Our state-of-the-art infrastructure and competent faculty prepare students to be future leaders in their chosen fields, whether it is sports or something else.

With deep-rooted passion for sports myself, I have ensured that Vels focuses on accessibility and identifies raw talent at the grass root level. We provide 100% scholarship to around 250 sports students every year. We also nurture them with specialised training and mentorship and enable them to develop their skills and build confidence.

Technology has enabled a robust exchange of ideas, learnings, and opened a plethora of opportunities for collaborations making them accessible. How are you turning around these vibrant possibilities in favour of India's ambitious vision?

The education sector in particular is rapidly moving towards digitization. Since the onset of the pandemic, digitisation has become more or less the norm, with children confined to their homes, new methodologies and tools have been utilized, be it Google classrooms or Microsoft teams. Vels is also developing content using AI and VR to be utilized when the online courses are introduced and plan to build a huge stockpile of digital resources in enabling recorded content to be accessed anywhere and at any time. Together with the timely introduction of courses based on emerging technologies such as Blockchain, IOT, Information security, etc. we aspire to equip the students with the latest developments in the world.

For India's Vision of a ten trillion-dollar economy by 2030 to be a reality, I am sure education will play a decisive role in bringing new age technologies closer to our homes and our work places. And so, we need to make quality education affordable to all. We at Vels are doing our best to reach out to students from rural and economically backward areas by offering merit scholarships and also free education.

What is your mantra of success that aspiring entrepreneurs can look forward to?

Every successful entrepreneur knows that there is no particular success mantra or formula for success. Perseverance, passion for the job, patience along with the willingness to learn will definitely produce the results expected.